Atomic Blue Pieces

By Angela Johnson

NARRATOR: **(Pg 41-48)** The day my brother Leon left, I broke my leg falling down the steps of an old deserted building that Mama had told me not to go in. I lay there half a day.

Somebody told me once you can't die from pain, even if you want to. You can make your world what you want it to be sometimes. So, there wasn't any pain for me, for a while. No pain. No busted leg. No pain.

If you count between thunderclaps during a storm you'll know whether the storm is coming or going during the next count. Lower number-it's coming at you. Higher number-it's leaving. I can count during a storm.

INTRODUCTION

For years, movies and country music have pointed out the benefits of living in a small town. A strong sense of community; everyone knows everyone and life is lived at a much slower pace. It's quiet and peaceful and it's easy to see the appeal for many who are exhausted by the rat race of the bigger cities. But what these idealized benefits hide are the downfalls: 1) Anonymity is a foreign concept, 2)

4NG Fanatics

There is literally nothing to do, 3) Limited career options, which results in higher levels of poverty. For many who were born into small town life, it can often seem like there's no way out.

Atomic Blue Pieces by Angela Johnson

NARRATOR: The morning before Leon left he shared half his toast with me and most of his bacon. We didn't get bacon that much, either. He'd sat there smiling at me while I picked out of his plate and babbled about nothing. Mama had already told me to be quiet, twice. Leon gave her dirty looks, though, and smiled back at me. I'd run my bare feet underneath the chair. The linoleum was gritty and cold. Leon kept smiling.

I found out that night after I'd gotten back from the emergency room that Leon was gone. I took an Atomic Blue Magic Marker and wrote my brother's name all over my cast. The day my brother Leon left was mostly white light and pain. But it also was atomic blue, bacon, and his face.

Chalky's Trailer Park is wedged up against Route 82 and Cave Man Woods. Everybody who grows up there spends most of their lives listening to people yelling at them to

EDUCATIONAL USE O

stay off the highway and not go into the swamp woods. That meant until you are sixteen or have a friend who can drive, you're stuck at Chalky's. Even though I'd been stuck, I'd had Leon and Cougar. We hung out in the swamp like all the kids who lived at Chalky's. It was all something else then. Something I could live with.

Didn't they know that they couldn't keep us away from everything that we were looking for? Didn't they know that sooner or later . . . Sooner or later . . .

Maybe Mama knew about sooner or later. Maybe she knew it when she'd go out with her girlfriends at Star Lanes Bowling. Maybe she even knew about sooner or later when she'd sit in the front window of our trailer all night long listening to Sam Cooke records and playing solitaire.

I only remember Mama at these times because of extremes. Extreme cold. Extreme heat. Leon says Mama is intense. And I wondered out loud once if that was the reason our dad left. Leon got mad when he heard me say it. He turned away from me and whispered, "She got intense after he left us."

4NG Fanatics

If I'd known Leon would leave us for good, I would have paid him back the ten dollars I owed him for fronting me movie tickets and nachos last month. I still dream that he'll come back for the money. Ten dollars is a lot of money when you have nothing. Did he have anything? Was he warm and safe? Did he think about us?"

Me and Mama walking around like ghosts at Chalky's. Mama wanting to stay home and go looking for him but knowing she couldn't afford to lose her job. Me waking up in the middle of history class calling out his name. Was he thinking about us?

In the end Leon had to go because no one but me would believe him. And that was funny ‘cause Leon is the most honest person in the world. So honest . . .

Leon has honor and morality that Mama always used to be proud of until it brought the cops and social services to our trailer. Was Leon thinking about us?

He'd play the African drums on the top of Selby's drugstore, well, what used to be Selby's. Leon said he loved to watch everybody from above six stories above. He wanted to play the drums for everybody. He did.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Sweet, faraway drumming all over the town.

Leon would drum on top of Selby's in the morning and just as the sun was going down. He'd drum everybody in Springhill awake and asleep. Sweet, faraway drumming like he was calling to people he never met in a country he'd never been to.

Leon's drumming made me sad. 'Cause I knew. I knew what I didn't want to know. Leon was not one of us. Even the us everybody our age in Springhill would probably become whether we wanted to or not. He wouldn't work at the turkey farm or go to Star Lanes on Friday night. He wouldn't stand along the fence watching high school football and talking about how he could have been.

He'd never put on a pig roast and stand around a bonfire passing a paper bag full of whiskey, like a lot did years after they couldn't run fast anymore and the weather channel was more important to them than the world news.

I know if Leon had stayed in the county and went to football games, the boy who drummed for us would be gone forever. The boy who used to let me sit beside him

4N6 Fanatics

and draw while he drummed would just vanish in the mist like people did in scary books. The boy who let me draw him drumming in blue as the sun set would disappear. And he did.

Mama cries all the time now, but I don't really think she's crying for Leon. I think she's crying for all the ones who have left her. Not for their sake, but her own.

Leon used to go to day camp with T-Boy James. They learned to swim together. But T-Boy had stuff happen to him. He changed from the kid who used to share his pudding with my brother. He turned nasty and danger-ous. His grandma cried when they dragged him away.

When T-Boy James got out of juvenile it didn't take him long to start messing with everybody that he thought put him there. That was a lot of people 'cause T-Boy did everything but kill before they finally locked him up.

Cougar got on the bus twice in two weeks with a bloody nose. Somebody had broken every window out of the science lab and keyed all the police cars parked by the courthouse. There was other stuff, but the night the block of apartments across from Selby's went up in flames was

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

one of the worst nights of my life.

An old lady didn't make it out. And a couple of hours later men were looking under our trailer and knocking the door in and dragging Leon off.

Mama went and picked Leon up from the police station that night. Both her and the legal aid lawyer she brought with her looked overworked and nervous.

Leon came home sleepy and quiet. He hugged me hard just before he crawled into bed with all his clothes on. I didn't know it then, but I only had a week to be in the company of my brother.

I used to wonder what would happen to me when Leon went away. I used to think that I'd probably miss him so bad, it would hurt. But I thought away meant college or a job in another state, so he'd come back to me and my loneliness . . .

In the end it didn't matter that T-Boy heard Leon drumming on Selby's roof when he poured the first drops of gasoline or that he hid the gas can under our trailer. It doesn't even matter that everybody would have found

4N6 Fanatics

out the truth about Leon in the end.

It's about pain. T-Boy's pain, Leon's pain, everybody's pain. The pains might never even have had to come together for my brother to leave this town. But he did. He did in broad daylight with a backpack and his drum under one arm. A man saw him get in a semi off Route 44. He said he was smiling when he got in.

I can't believe that though, 'cause I heard Leon on the roof way after that man says he got in the truck. I can still smell the smoke of the gutted building across the street as I climbed the steps to the roof. Sweet drumming. Sweet Leon playing . . . I even thought I heard him as I fell and visions of atomic blue drawings and pain shot through me.

I always count during the pain, now. Two thousand one, two thousand two ... Higher numbers it's coming-lower numbers it's going away.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Angela Johnson
Book: The Color of Absence (Pg 41-48)
ISBN: 978-0689856679
Publisher: Atheneum Books
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2003

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY